

HARMEET SODHI

RADICAL FAITH
Sikh protesters gather at Fountain Chowk in Patiala after the clash with the 'Shiv Sena (BT)', Apr. 29

Barjinder Parwana, for his outfit's part in the violence.

Punjab chief minister Bhagwant Mann has given reassurances after the Patiala and Mohali incidents that the state police will crack down on all elements creating trouble in the state. "The police are investigating the Mohali blast. Those who conspire to disrupt the peace and harmony in the state will not be spared," said Mann, who also heads the home ministry. However, the opposition BJP is not convinced. "The police and security agencies are pointing fingers at the Khalistanis, but the CM refuses to criticise them," says Subhash Sharma, the BJP state unit general secretary.

Meanwhile, in Himachal Pradesh, a Special Investigation Team is probing a curious case from the night of May 7 when Khalistani flags were found tied to the gates of the state (winter) assembly building in Dharamshala. The police again see the hand of SFJ's Pannun in instigating local elements.

The response of state governments to such incidents suggests a growing focus on the involvement of criminal gangs in the name of 'Khalistan'. The new AAP government led by Mann has constituted an anti-gangster squad in the Punjab police under ADGP Pramod Ban, but it's early days yet. Police sources say there are 70 organised gangs with over 500 known members active in the state. Some 300 gangsters are lodged in different jails. The number of gangs has risen three times in the preceding 5-7 years. One of them, led by Rinda, has extended the gangster network in north India to pro-Khalistani militant outfits run from Pakistan, say security agencies. These cross-border outfits apparently include the Wadhawa Singh Babbar-led Babbar Khalsa International (BKI), the Lakhbir Singh Rode—nephew of slain terrorist Jarnail Singh Bhindrawale—led Khalistan Liberation Force (KLF), Ranjeet Singh Neeta-led Khalistan Zindabad Force (KZF) and Paramjit Panjwar's Khalistan Commando Force (KCF). All these outfits are reportedly busy these days pushing counterfeit currency, drugs and arms into India along with ordering targeted killings and attacks. Rinda is suspected to have fled to Pakistan via Nepal in 2019 on a fake passport and joined Babbar's outfit. He apparently organised the blasts in Ludhiana, Nawanshahr and at a police station in Ropar earlier this year to create a name for himself.

Early last year, Punjab Police successfully extradited another gangster, Sukh Bhikhariwal, from Dubai. His gang is suspected to have executed anti-Khalistan activist and Shaurya Chakra winner Balwinder Sandhu in Tarn Taran district on the instruction of KLF's Rode. In January this year, in a joint operation, police in the Ramdas area of Amritsar and Dinanagar area of Gurdaspur cracked a clique of gangsters apparently working as couriers for Rode and KCF's Panjwar.

Former Punjab DGP Shashikant says Khalistani outfits are trying again to destabilise the peaceful atmosphere in the state by targeting social and religious leaders. Retired Punjab Police IG Jagdish Mittal pulls out state police data to suggest that in the past decade, these groups may have executed more than 100 people, including RSS leaders, Hindu leaders of outfits linked to the Congress, leaders of fringe Hindutva outfits, Christian pastors etc.



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BHAGWANT MANN
Chief Minister, Punjab

Rinda was also allegedly using his network to ship arms consignments to terror groups in Punjab and Kashmir, and Maoists in central and east India. On May 5, after inputs from the Intelligence Bureau (IB) and Punjab Police's intelligence wing, the Haryana police nabbed four gangsters—Gurpreet Singh, Amandeep Singh, Parminder Singh and Bhupinder Singh—who were suspected to be carriers hired by Rinda to deliver explosives at Adilabad in Telangana. Border Security Force (BSF) teams, along with police teams from Maharashtra and Telangana, are currently camping in Haryana's Karnal for their interrogation. The Haryana police recovered improvised explosive devices (IEDs), 7.5 kg of RDX, 30 live cartridges, a pistol and Rs 1.3 lakh in cash from them at a toll plaza in Karnal. Security agencies believe the four have already delivered two consignments in Nanded, Maharashtra, and suspect that the plan